



About the Artist: Charu Jain

Diabetes Care 2026;49:1295 | <https://doi.org/10.2337/dci26-0082>

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About the Artist

It began with whales. While on a trip to Alaska with her family, Charu Jain saw a group of humpbacks bubble-net feeding, a type of hunting in which whales create a wall of bubbles to entrap a school of fish. It was during this trip that Jain took her first art class, a chance to paint whales like those seen in the wild.

But Jain's art draws more from form than subject. While she began with acrylic paints, she has experimented with various media over the years, including wood sculpting and printmaking. "Anything tactile," she says. For her high school portfolio, she made a series of medical illustrations.

"I was interested in science," she says. "My father was a pediatrician, but because I grew up around medicine, I wanted nothing to do with it at first." But a medical path, she realized, provided an opportunity to work with her hands. After attending Stanford University for her undergraduate degree, Jain is currently in her second year of medical school at the Icahn School of Medicine at Mount Sinai in New York City, with a focus in surgery.

"I began woodworking in college around the same time that I shadowed an orthopedic surgeon, and I noticed a lot of parallels between art and medicine," she says. "The way you prep for a painting is similar to the way you scrub into surgery. You prepare your supplies in the same way you gather instruments in the operating room. There's an art to it all."

On the Cover: *Beside My Father*

While Jain grew up in Mount Vernon, IL, her parents are from India. It was during another family trip that she found another inspiration. "We visited Rajasthan, where they had these beautiful fabrics designed



Charu Jain

with block printing," she says. "When I got home, I carved stamps out of linoleum that echoed these Indian patterns."

For this month's issue of *Diabetes Care*, Jain submitted a more elaborate form of

printmaking. *Beside My Father* is made from two sheets of poplar wood that she carved based on a photograph taken by her mother.

"It's me and my dad. The way we both had our hands on our heads, the way we looked so similar to one another—it's almost a generational image," she says.

Jain remembers when her father was diagnosed with type 2 diabetes. "Our entire family adjusted its lifestyle to help him keep it under control," she says. "He wanted to set a good example for his patients."

The print illustrates the effect that diabetes has had on the lives of both Jain and her father.

"He likes to talk to me. We go for long walks and he talks with me about medicine, about cars, about stocks. And he talks about how his life has changed, how his stamina is lower than it used to be," she says. "On this particular day he was so exhausted. So we came home and we sat together. A nice moment I wanted to capture in some way."

